

Attribution & Tracking Audit Framework

A practical framework for finding out what your numbers are actually telling you
— built from real cross-market and cross-brand audits.

The more markets, brands and channels a business runs, the more likely each one tracks performance differently — and the more expensive that inconsistency becomes. This is the same four-layer framework I've used to rebuild attribution across 13 brands in 4 markets (Mars) and a £2bn global portfolio (Tata Communications).

The Four-Layer Audit

1 Taxonomy Layer

Is there one shared UTM and campaign naming convention across every market, channel and agency? If everyone names campaigns differently, nothing rolls up cleanly — and every report becomes a manual reconciliation exercise.

2 Platform Layer

What does each ad platform claim on its own (Meta, Google, TikTok, etc.)? Note: platform-reported numbers are almost always inflated relative to what actually happened — that's not a conspiracy, it's how attribution windows and self-reporting work.

3 Independent Layer

What does your own analytics or CRM say, independent of any platform's self-reported numbers? This is your reality check — the number that doesn't have an incentive to look good.

4 Reconciliation Layer

Where platform and independent numbers disagree, which one do you trust, and why? This is usually where the real insight lives — and where most businesses simply stop looking.

Red flags your attribution is lying to you

- ! Different regions or brands use different UTM structures
- ! Platform-reported ROAS is meaningfully higher than revenue finance can actually tie out
- ! Nobody can explain a sudden performance swing without guessing
- ! Reporting requires manual reconciliation every single month
- ! Two people can pull "the same" report and get different numbers

What good looks like

- ✓ One taxonomy, enforced across every market and agency, no exceptions
- ✓ A standing reconciliation process between platform and independent numbers
- ✓ Clear ownership — one person who is the actual source of truth
- ✓ Reporting a CEO can read and trust in five minutes, not fifty

Faisal Mahmud

Fractional Marketing Director

I've rebuilt this exact system at Mars (13 brands, 4 markets) and Tata Communications (£2bn portfolio).
If your numbers don't fully add up, that's usually fixable within weeks. Book a free 20-minute diagnostic call at faisalconsulting.co.uk